FREE GUIDE

# Who Am I? Identity and Diversity

A gentle, factual guide to sex, gender and the many kinds of families and relationships that make up our communities.

**WHO IT IS FOR**
Autistic children and young people, with the parents, carers, teachers and SNAs who support them.

**NCCA STAGE**
Primary · Junior Cycle · Senior Cycle and LCA (use the sections that suit the age)

**Easy read**

People are different. Families are different. Everyone is a person who matters. We are kind to everyone.

## How to use this resource

- Read the sections that suit the age and needs of the young person. You do not have to read everything.
- Use the family cards for talking. Ask: 'Who lives in your home?' Let the young person lead.
- Use the same words every time, and answer questions simply and factually.
- Families have many beliefs and values. This guide gives facts and respect. It does not tell anyone what to believe.

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## Everyone is a person who matters

Every person in the world is different. We have different bodies, families, beliefs, interests and ways of thinking. Autistic people are one part of this variety. We all have the right to feel safe and to be treated with respect.

I am a person. I matter.

Other people matter too.

I am kind and respectful to everyone.

We all have the right to feel safe.

## Sex and gender

These words are used in different ways. Here are simple meanings. Words and ideas about this are still being discussed, and people hold a range of views.

### Sex

A word for a person's body, such as having a penis and testicles, or a vulva, vagina and womb. At birth, babies are usually called a boy or a girl based on their body. Some people are born with a body that does not fit neatly into one group.

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### Gender

Who a person knows themselves to be, such as a boy, a girl, both or neither. For most people, this matches the word given at birth. For some people, it does not.

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### Attraction

Who a person feels drawn to, romantically or sexually. Some people are attracted to people of a different gender, some to the same gender, some to more than one, and some to nobody.

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### Pronouns

Words we use for a person, such as he, she or they. The kind thing to do is to use the words a person asks us to use.

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I can know who I am slowly.

I can ask a trusted adult my questions.

I do not tease or hurt anyone because they are different.

**Notes for adults**

- Answer questions factually, calmly and in a few words. A short, true answer is better than silence or an awkward change of subject.
- Some autistic young people have questions about identity and gender. Take them seriously and do not assume it is a 'phase' or 'just autism'. Equally, do not push a label. Let them explore at their own pace.
- Support is available. BeLonG To (belongto.org) supports LGBTQ+ young people in Ireland.
- Respect families of all beliefs. Teach facts and respect for people. Families and schools may add their own values.

## Families come in many shapes

A family is the people who care for you and live with you or love you. There are many kinds of families. All of them can be happy, safe, loving homes.



### Mum and Dad

A child lives with a mum and a dad, and maybe brothers and sisters.

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### One-parent family

A child lives with one parent. The parent may be a mum or a dad.

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### Two mums

A child has two mums who love and look after them.

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### Two dads

A child has two dads who love and look after them.

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### Grandparents raising grandchildren

A grandmother or grandfather looks after the child at home.

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### Foster family

A child lives with a foster family for a while, or for a long time. Social workers help.

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### Step-family

A parent has a new partner. Stepbrothers or stepsisters may join the family.

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### Adoptive family

A child has been adopted. Their parents became their parents by law.

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### Family with two homes

A child lives in two homes, with each parent, on different days.

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### My family

**The people in my home:** _____

**People who care about me:** _____

**A thing we like doing together:** _____

**Notes for adults**

- Let the child describe their own family. Use their words. Do not assume who a child's parents are.
- When a child asks why another family is different, say: 'Families are different. They all love their children.'
- Be sensitive in activities such as Mother's Day or family-tree tasks. Offer choices: 'someone who looks after me'.

## Relationships between adults

Adults can have different kinds of relationships. Some adults marry. Some live together. Some live alone. In Ireland, a couple can be a man and a woman, two men or two women. Many people are single, and some are happily single their whole lives.



### Partners

Two adults who love each other and choose to be together.

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### Marriage

Two adults make a promise to each other in front of the law. In Ireland, marriage is open to two adults of any gender.

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### Living together

Some partners live together without being married.

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### Single

Some adults are single. It is a good way to live too.

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## Words we might hear

| Word | What it means |
|---|---|
| Family | The people who love and look after a child or adult. |
| Parent | A mum, a dad, a stepparent, a foster parent or an adoptive parent who looks after a child. |
| Guardian | An adult who looks after a child and is responsible for them. |
| Sex | A word for the body a person has, such as a penis and testicles, or a vulva and vagina. |

| Word | What it means |
|---|---|
| Gender | Who a person knows themselves to be. |
| Transgender (trans) | A person whose gender is different from the word they were given at birth. |
| Gay | A word for someone attracted to people of the same gender. It is often used for men. |
| Lesbian | A woman who is attracted to women. |
| Bisexual | A person who is attracted to more than one gender. |
| Heterosexual (straight) | A person attracted to people of a different gender. |
| Asexual | A person who feels little or no sexual attraction. |
| LGBTQ+ | A short way to talk about lesbian, gay, bisexual, trans, queer and other people. |
| Respect | Treating a person kindly and listening to them, even when we are different. |



Some words are used as insults. I do not use them.



If someone is teased, I tell a teacher.

## Being kind and respectful

A classmate has two mums and someone laughs



**Families are different. Stop laughing, please.**

You want to know why a person is different



**Can I ask a question? I do not want to be rude.**

A person tells you they are gay, trans or not sure



**Thank you for telling me. I will keep it private.**

You hear a mean word



**That is not kind. I do not like that word.**


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You have a question about yourself

### I have a question. Can I talk to you about it?

**Remember**

- Private information is not ours to share. If someone tells you something about who they are, you do not tell others.
- Some people find it hard to talk about this with their family. They can talk to a trusted adult, a school counsellor or BeLonG To (belongto.org).
- Asking questions is OK. Being unkind is not.

**Notes for adults**

- All schools must teach SPHE and RSE in a way that is inclusive and respectful of all students. Schools can teach this in line with their ethos while treating every student and family with respect.
- Families of all beliefs have a part to play. Share what is being taught with parents and carers, and invite questions. Parents' and carers' views matter, and so does every child's right to feel safe and respected.
- Bullying based on difference should be dealt with under your school's anti-bullying procedures. For young people, a trusted adult, GP or Childline (1800 66 66 66) can help.
- If a young person tells you something that worries you about their safety, follow Children First and your school's Child Protection Procedures.

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## Curriculum links

### NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Primary SPHE (1999), strands **Myself** and **Myself and Others**, including strand units *Taking care of my body*, *Growing and changing* and *My friends and other people*; Stay Safe programme and the RSE programme are taught within SPHE.
- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 1 *Understanding Myself and Others* and Strand 3 *Relationships and Sexuality*, including respect for diversity and different kinds of relationships and families.
- Senior Cycle SPHE: new specification published 2024, being introduced for fifth years. Leaving Certificate Applied: Social Education.

### Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

## Getting support in Ireland

### BeLonG To

Support for LGBTQ+ young people in Ireland at belongto.org.

### Text About It

Free text support any time: text HELLO to 50808.

### Childline (ISPCC)

Free, 24 hours: phone 1800 66 66 66, text 50101, or chat at childline.ie. For anyone under 18.

### Parentline

Support for parents and carers: 01 873 3500, parentline.ie.

### Your school

Talk to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP) for child safeguarding, a class tutor or year head.

### Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

### If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

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